by the merchants travelling along the routes of the Great Silk Road. In Damaskus, local smiths hammered swords and sabers which gained popularity both in the Orient and in Europe.

At the beginning of the thirteenth century Aksikent suffered the plundering raid of Kara-Khitan tribes, and later, in AD 1228, the Ferghana valley was conquered by one of Genghiz-khan's commanders—Jebe Noyan. The ruler of Aksikent, Ismoil, surrendered to the conquerors and even agreed to guide the Mongols in their raid against Samarkand. However, plundered and ruined by the Mongols Aksikent fell into decay. Only under Amir Timur the town was built up anew in several kilometers down the Syr Darya river to the west from ancient, pre-Mongol Aksikent. This new town on the steep riverbank occupied the area of one hundred hectares. And even though it lost its status of a capital city of the Ferghana Valley, it continued to be one of the most important trade and crafts centres. This is evidenced by numerous findings of glassware, metalware, and ceramics. The new entrenched citadel and the palace soon became the favourite residence of the Ferghana rulers.

Aksikent was razed to the ground in AD 1620 by a severe earthquake. The citizens who managed to survive this natural disaster moved to the north-east, to Namakkon settlement next to the salt-mines. Today this settlement is known as Namangan—a big regional center.

The ruins of Aksikent citadel look like the creation of nature, not the product of man's activity. Hardly visible are the remains of brickwork of once majestic buildings. From the mud walls, just as a thousand years ago, one can see the Syr Darya banks buried in verdure of gardens and groves.